



Systran's translation software and services are the most popular choice for Web sites

How good are they?

We used Google, Systran, Dictionary.com, AltaVista and FreeTranslation.com to translate a snippet of a popular French song into English. We then translated the output back into French and then back into English, just to see what the sites would come up with.

The snippet in French was: "J'avais dessin , sur le sable, son doux visage, qui me souriait. Et puis, il a plu, sur cette plage, et dans cet orage, elle a disparu. Et j'ai cri , cri ! "Alline!" pour qu'elle revienne. Et j'ai pleur , pleur , Oh! J'avais trop de peine."

Here's what it means when translated by a competent human translator: "I drew her sweet face, which smiled at me, upon the sand. And then it rained on this beach. And in this storm, she disappeared. And I cried out, "Alline!" so she'd come back. And I cried, cried. Oh! I am hurting so much."

Google came up with: "I had drawn, on sand, his soft face, which smiled I. And

The languages they speak...						
	AltaVista BabelFish	Dicti- onary.com	FreeTransla- tion.com	Google	Systran	T-Mail.com
Chinese <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✗	✓	✓
Dutch <=> English	✓	✓	✗	✗	✓	✓
French <=> English	✗	✓	✓	✗	✓	✗
German <=> English	✗	✓	✓	✗	✓	✗
Greek <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Italian <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Japanese <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Korean <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Norwegian <=> English	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
Portuguese <=> English	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗
Russian <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Spanish <=> English	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

then, he liked, on this beach, and in this storm, he disappeared. And J? shouted, shouted! for the qu? it turns over. And I cried, cried, the OH! J?avais, too much pain."

AltaVista's Babel Fish translation service also uses Systran's Internet translation technology to translate text and Web pages, and thus gave the exact same output as Google.

FreeTranslation.com's machine translator came up with: "I had drawn, on the sand, his soft face, that smiled me. And then, it pleased, on this beach, and in this storm, she disappeared. And j's? screamed, screamed! "Alline!" for qu' she returns herself. And cried j, cried, Oh! J'avais, the too much penalty."

Dictionary.com offers many more languages to translate between, but our passage was just as badly translated. It came up with: "I had drawn, on sand, his soft face, which smiled I. And then, he liked, on this beach, and in this storm, he disappeared. And j’ shouted, shouted! “Alline!& #8221; for qu’ he turns over. And I cried, cried, the OH! J’avais, too much pain."

Systran's translation was the best: "I had drawn, on sand, his soft face, which smiled I. And then, he liked, on this beach, and in this storm, he disappeared. And I shouted, shouted! "Alline!" so that it turns over. And I cried, cried, the OH! I had,

You'd probably get the idea from these translations that Systran, Free-Translation.com and all the others do a terrible job. But remember that prose, especially simple sentences, get translated much better than poetry and the like. Also remember that we got the results above by translating from French to English, then back to French and back again, just in order to see how well the final translation would come out. The results are much better for a single one-way translation.

Future speak

With better speech recognition and translation software being developed, we could soon have only geographical barriers separating us. IBM is developing a Multilingual Automatic Speech to Speech Translator (MASTOR), allowing people who do not share a common language to communicate. If you have a laptop with the software loaded, you can talk into the microphone, and the laptop will translate and speak to your audience in their native tongue, and vice versa.

Technology and software that can recognise your speech, your tone of voice and mood, are also being developed. Once perfected, all we will ever need is our laptops on our travels abroad. The software will convert whatever we write, speak and hear into any language accurately.

For now, those of us who are interested in all things alien, can use the current online services for basic translation needs and wait for them to evolve. Till then, we have no choice but to live with the imperfections of current machine translators.

ROBERT SOVEREIGN-SMITH

Trekkie translation

Calling all Trekkies! There is a Web site that has translation services for alien languages from Star Trek—namely Klingon, Vulcan and Romulan. You can convert from these to English or vice versa. Now you can watch the reruns and understand what the Klingons and Romulans are saying. Try it at <http://startrek.t35.com:8000/php/entrans.php>



Translation tools that will help while navigating in space